

Exerciser at the Gym

It is 4:00 pm, and you are at work. You see a workout session you scheduled for yourself for 5:00 pm on your calendar. You are tired and stressed out from work, and a little voice from within is telling you to go home and relax. You decide to use imagery techniques to help increase your motivation to go to the gym.

Emotions/Feelings

You first imagine yourself getting into your car and driving to the fitness center despite the fact that you just feel like going home.

You arrive at the facility. As you visualize yourself changing in the locker room, you feel the stressors of the day begin to evaporate. You walk out to the gym floor and start to do some light flexibility exercises; you feel the tension melt away. After getting rid of the muscular tension in your neck and shoulders, you feel energized and even a little pumped up and excited as you get ready to begin your exercise regimen.



Shutterstock.com/Mladen Zivkovic

Appearance

Before you begin exercising, you see yourself in the mirror looking more like the way you want to—and you imagine yourself at the gym actually belonging there. You notice your waist has gotten smaller; it also appears as though you have more definition in your arms and legs. It is a fitter you that you see, and you like it. Your more toned body makes you feel relaxed, confident, and strong in clothing you had avoided wearing for so long. It has been a long time since you have been happy about your appearance, so this is a real boost to your confidence.

It's now 5:10 pm. You have successfully made it to the gym and you have completed your pre-workout warm-up routine. You are now ready for some cardiorespiratory work using the treadmill.

Exercise Technique

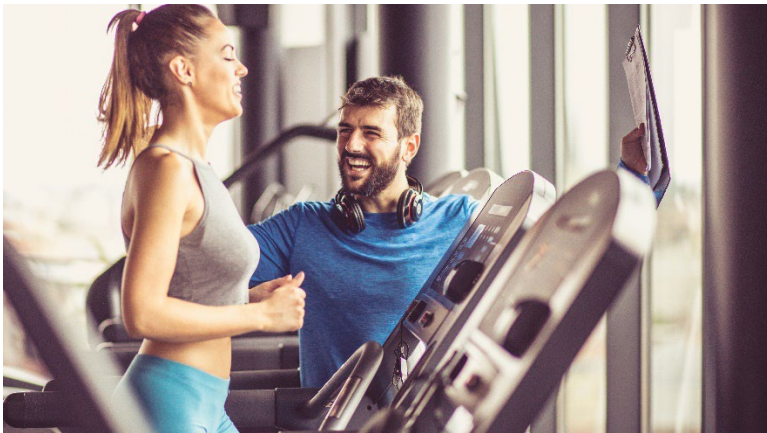
You start by seeing yourself stepping onto the equipment and slowly increasing your speed. As you start off slow, you get your body in ideal alignment by keeping your shoulders back and your chin tucked in. You also keep your back in a neutral position by engaging your abdominal muscles, simultaneously making sure that you are walking with your feet pointed straight ahead. You feel stronger and taller in this alignment. As you maintain good posture, you

increase the treadmill speed and start in a slow jog. Your breath is still under control but you can feel your body getting ready for the exercise ahead. Your heart starts to pump a little harder and you increase the speed and even the incline. Your intensity is getting to where it should be at this point and you are breathing in through your nose and out through your mouth, maintaining a rhythm even with the increased difficulty. Your eyes remain focused straight ahead and your body is still in ideal alignment. Because you are keeping good posture, you can feel yourself working in all the right places, instead of pain or discomfort. Your heart starts to pump harder but you remain energized as one of your favorite songs comes on.

You have now completed 15 minutes of your 30-minute cardiorespiratory workout. Your legs are tired but you would like to move on to start the last 15 minutes. You are not sure if you will be able to keep up your pace for the entire 15 minutes, so you use imagery to help give yourself the confidence to complete the workout.

Self-Efficacy

You see yourself starting up and getting into your rhythm. As every minute goes by, you get more and more confident that you can really do this. Completing the first 15 minutes is a real boost to your confidence. You see yourself working at a consistent pace and pushing past the discomfort you feel in your quadriceps, hamstrings, and lungs. You increase your incline as “the hills” are coming up, but you are confident you can get through it. You remember when



Shutterstock.com/Mladen Zivkovic

you started this exercise program you could barely last 10 minutes with no incline. Running the entire 30 minutes has increased your confidence that you really can stick with an exercise program, and you are feeling vastly better about yourself. You see yourself power through the hills and then finally move on to a nice, easy steady state until you complete the 15 minutes. What an accomplishment—you are really proud of yourself for sticking with the program.